

Chapter 49-1: Accompanying You

As soon as the words fell, Ning Fuyi clearly sensed Chu Qingqiu's breathing becoming heavier. If one listened carefully, one could even hear the creaking sound of her knuckles as she gripped the white bone tightly.

"Aunt?" The woman's face showed visible disappointment, then her gaze shifted to Ning Fuyi's face, examining her like merchandise. "This young lady is so young, how could she be an aunt?"

"City people," Ning Fuyi said without blushing or skipping a beat. "Well-maintained."

The woman nodded half-believingly, then pulled Ning Fuyi over. Her heavily lined palm rubbed against Ning Fuyi's hand, and she smiled broadly: "Aren't you two looking for lodging? My house is a bit messy, but there are two empty rooms. There's rain today, and it would be dangerous to be trapped in the mountains. Please stay at my house for the night."

Without waiting for Ning Fuyi to respond, she dragged her toward the deeper part of the mountain hollow. Ning Fuyi looked back and gave Chu Qingqiu a sheepish smile. Chu Qingqiu pressed her lips together, exhaled, and lifted her legs to follow.

There weren't many people along the way, and everyone's face bore the numbness of having weathered many storms. Their lifeless gazes always fell on the two women, staring straight at them without blinking.

Even after walking far away, they would still turn back to look, as if they had never seen women in their entire lives.

The woman carried a wooden mallet for beating clothes as she walked ahead. Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu fell behind. Ning Fuyi moved closer to the cold-faced Chu Qingqiu: "I said you were my aunt for your own good. Look at her expression - she's clearly taken with your beauty and has improper intentions."

"You're quite clever." Chu Qingqiu said faintly, her voice revealing no joy or anger.

"Besides, I'm not really being presumptuous." Ning Fuyi's red lips curved. "Divine Venerable and my mother..."

She paused here, then continued: "I originally wanted to say you were my maternal aunt, but calling you paternal aunt is more convenient. This way they'll have fewer improper thoughts."

"I have no relationship with Ning Changfeng." Chu Qingqiu lowered her brows.

As the two spoke in low voices, an earthen house appeared before them. The outside was walled with low stone barriers, with wild grass growing from the cracks between stones. Several dirty hens clucked in the courtyard. The house consisted of several rooms built together, with a pig pen on the left side that reeked terribly, making Ning Fuyi quickly cover her nose.

She was about to walk a few steps toward the pig pen when the woman hurried to stop her: "Oh my! Why are you young ladies from outside running toward the pig pen? It's filthy and stinking!"

"The house is over here, over here!" She cheerfully led the two toward the house.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu exchanged glances and followed her inside. They were greeted by the smell of wood ash throughout the house. Much ash was scattered in the corners, and several pieces of paper talismans were pasted in inconspicuous corners. Ning Fuyi scanned them and found they were all ghost-warding charms.

The talismans were correct, but the person who pasted them was obviously an ordinary person, so these things were completely useless.

"My house is simple, please don't mind it." The woman busied herself bringing them water.

"No need to trouble yourself." Chu Qingqiu said, not knowing where to put the cup, finally placing it on a broken wooden cabinet in the corner. "May I ask why there are so many talismans pasted here..."

Upon hearing this, the woman's eyes rolled around, and she smiled as she answered: "They're for warding off evil. Our village has bad feng shui¹ - it faces the blade tip of Axe Head Mountain, so every household pastes them."

Knowing the woman was lying, the two didn't expose her. Just then, a child with a big head and small body ran in from outside, snot hanging from his nose tip to his collar, clapping his hands foolishly: "Granny, my dad fell in the manure pit again!"

"That damned..." Upon hearing this, the woman was about to rush out cursing, then realized there were outsiders present and swallowed her curses, suppressing her anger: "That's my lame son. Young ladies, please sit, I'll be right back."

"Niu Dan², entertain the guests!" She instructed the child, then hurried away with her wooden mallet.

The child didn't look very smart, with snot constantly running that he didn't wipe, just grinning foolishly at them. Ning Fuyi's eyes sparkled as she secretly took out a candy from her prayer beads and handed it to him.

The child immediately snatched the candy and popped it in his mouth.

"Sister has some questions for you. If you answer honestly, these candies will all be yours." Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes narrowed slightly as she took out several more candies, bouncing them in her hand.

The child's eyes were practically glued to the candies, grinning and nodding repeatedly.

"What are these talismans and the wood ash scattered on the ground for? Did your granny ever mention it?" Ning Fuyi asked in a low voice.

The child's expression suddenly changed, his eyes slowly widening, making his already large head look like it was stuck on his body. He stared straight at Ning Fuyi and let out a withered laugh.

"Because there are ghosts." He said with a grin.

The child's unique laughter sent chills through one's bones. Chu Qingqiu, who had been standing in the corner, couldn't help but close her eyes.

However, Ning Fuyi was obviously unaffected and continued pursuing: "What ghosts?"

The child was about to speak when terrified screams suddenly erupted from the courtyard. A man's foul curses and a woman's sharp wails intertwined, shattering the quiet mountain village.

Hearing this commotion, the child also crouched down holding his head and joined the screaming. For a moment, chaos erupted both inside and outside the courtyard. Seeing she couldn't get any more information, Ning Fuyi looked up irritably toward the door.

She saw a woman running into the courtyard, her clothes tattered and covered with mud and grass. She carried a bundle on her chest that seemed to contain a baby, which was also crying along with her wails. Behind her followed a limping man holding a donkey cart whip, using all his strength to lash the woman.

While whipping, he cursed: "You poisonous woman! Did you deliberately not pull me up, causing me to fall into that manure pit! See if I don't beat you to death today, you useless wretch..."

The rough hemp clothing couldn't block the whip. The woman was soon bloody and torn, with no power to fight back. She could only hold the baby tightly and use her back to block the man's whip.

Witnessing all this, Chu Qingqiu had already clenched her fists. Her fingertips trembled slightly, and the previously aggressive man suddenly tripped and fell. As he hit the ground, the whip curved in mid-air and left a bloody mark on his face.

"Ow!" He covered his face and howled in pain.

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu had already rushed out, Ning Fuyi quickly lifted her skirts to follow. When the two arrived, the woman who had been standing silently outside the courtyard finally rushed in frantically, struggling to help up the reeking, limping man.

She chattered reproachfully: "I say, Da Lang, Qiu Lan is your wife. When she makes mistakes, beating is one thing, but you can't beat her to death! Especially with guests here today. Come, come."

She pinched the man as she spoke. The man turned his head and stared straight at Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu for a long while without speaking. Finally, he threw down the whip and limped back to the main room.

The door slammed shut with a rumble, and ash fell from the walls.

"Sorry for the disturbance, young ladies. That was my eldest son Da Lang, and this is Da Lang's wife." The woman smiled ingratiatingly, then kicked the woman on the ground and changed her tone: "Hurry up and go cook!"

The woman's disheveled hair covered her face. Holding the child, she got up submissively, her eyes darting around, not daring to look up.

Though she looked exhausted, her appearance was quite delicate, and she wasn't very old.

Chu Qingqiu obviously couldn't stand this. Her palm hidden in her sleeve clenched hard as stone, and she endured for a long time before loosening it.

The woman was calling them to enter. Ning Fuyi tugged at Chu Qingqiu's sleeve, signaling her to be more patient, then smiled: "Auntie, let's go in."

But before she finished speaking, she suddenly caught sight of something from the corner of her eye and said in surprise: "Is that a human face in the pig pen?"

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu turned toward the reeking pig pen. The moment she saw that snow-white face, her mind buzzed, and the white bone at her waist nearly flew out.

Fortunately, she was always rational. She pressed down on the white bone and looked carefully, and only then did her buzzing mind quiet down somewhat.

The fact that the Divine Venerable was afraid of ghosts had been unknown for thousands of years - even Ning Changfeng, who constantly pestered her, didn't know.

Now that Ning Fuyi had discovered this, it was already embarrassing, so she absolutely couldn't be exposed further.

"It's a person." She said in a suppressed voice, pretending nothing had happened.

The thick clouds overhead would affect divine consciousness, making it impossible to quickly detect whether there were people or ghosts around, further limiting her judgment.

"Oh my! My Er Lang!" The woman also saw the face in the pig pen and hurriedly waved her arms as she rushed over, opening the fence and pulling out that face.

It turned out to be indeed a person, just wearing all black and blending with the shadows in the pig pen. Besides that, his face was covered with flour, so from a distance it looked like a snow-white face.

He was forcefully pulled out of the pig pen by the woman, patting his chest and laughing foolishly, revealing a blood-red mouth.

"Sorry, sorry! This is my Er Lang. He was born simple-minded!" The woman apologized to Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu with a smile, dragging the person back into the house.

Both Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu breathed sighs of relief. Facing these oddities, they walked back into the house with steady steps.

Footnotes:

¹ **Feng shui (风水)**: The traditional Chinese practice of arranging living spaces to achieve harmony with the natural environment

² **Niu Dan (牛蛋)**: Literally "Bull Egg" - a rustic nickname for the child